

THE_PERIPHERAL_FILES: COLLECTED WORKS

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BLAIR BOULEVARD

Consisting of The Peripheral Files Parts A & B, and as such including the stories: Static Veil, Golden Season, Valley Echoes and Compliance.

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The Peripheral Files: Collected Works

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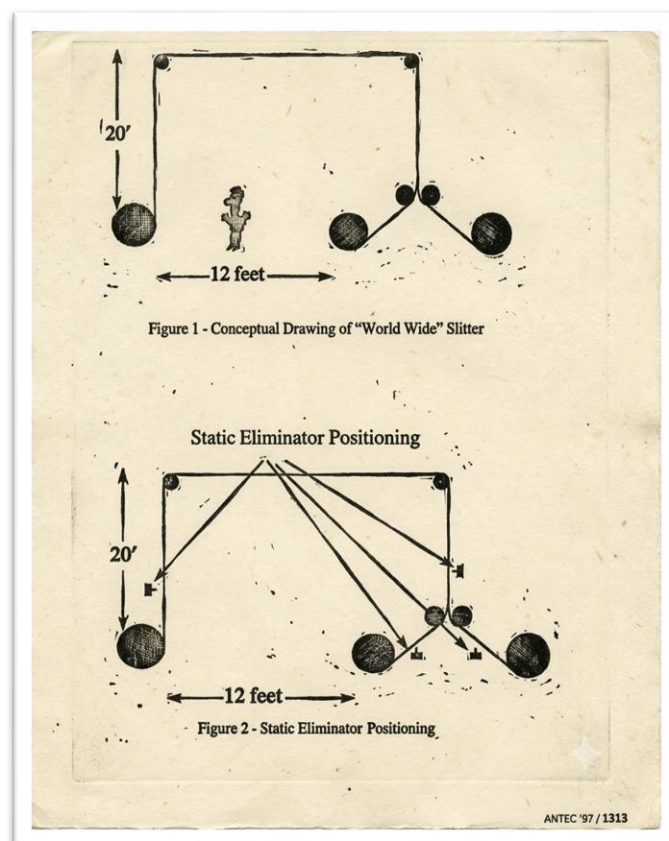
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>>> THE_PERIPHERAL_FILES_-_PART_A

The Peripheral Files are to be found in the DOE's Cold Events Archive - a digital graveyard of misplaced anomalies - an immense collection of disorganized, mislabelled and sometimes half-corrupted document files, mostly *misfiled* and having filenames like: PSYCHOMIMETIC_BRN_POISN/PDUE_1977-37F_OLD.tar.gz, and even worse - much of this wasn't entirely accidental or laziness. "Investigating" these, as she puts it, or moreover, to stay closer to the actual remit of her task, "Tidying that mess", has become the task of one Dr Alix Vale - what follows is a look at some of the more interesting files unearthed so far...



For Rusty because I tried to scare him with the original version when I was beginning the idea.

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Book 1:

STATIC VEIL

Part I: Dielectric Corridor (1980)

Florence, South Carolina — August 1980

The heat was already clinging to the walls when David Swenson pulled into the 3M lot just after 6:00 AM. The morning shift hadn't clocked in yet, but the call had come through before sunrise. An incident in Bay 12. A crew lead had refused to re-enter the extrusion corridor. Swenson's gut told him it was another static mishap. Routine. Maybe someone got zapped and wanted hazard pay.

He didn't expect a forcefield.

The plant air was thick, saturated. The humidity had crept up overnight and held firm — over 90%, if he had to guess. His boots squelched softly on the floor as he crossed the yellow-taped boundary into the extrusion line sector. Bay 12 loomed ahead: twenty-foot rolls of clear polypropylene were still spooling silently in their vacuum-dampened cradles. Machines cycled with their usual rhythm.

Yet something was wrong.

The temperature dropped.

Subtly at first — just a chill at the edges of his fingertips. But as he approached the corridor formed by the unrolling plastic film, it became undeniable. Cold. Dense. Heavy. The kind of cold you feel in your teeth. His breath steamed faintly in front of him despite the sweltering August outside.

Swenson paused and unhooked the handheld electrometer from his belt. The model could handle up to 200 kilovolts per foot. He flicked it on, pointed it down the line toward the zone where the two films unspooled in parallel, forming a clear tunnel of static friction.

The needle buried itself immediately.

200 kV/ft — and climbing. The analogue dial trembled, buzzed — then sparked. The device smoked and hissed in his hand, the casing suddenly too hot to hold. He dropped it. It shattered on the concrete.

His hair lifted. All of it — arms, neck, the fine threads on his knuckles. Not just from fear. From voltage. The corridor was alive.

Dust motes floated before him, held in suspension. Not falling. Not rising. Just... stuck. The two sheets of polypropylene hummed, a low, insectoid thrum that seemed to shift pitch as he stepped forward. The film itself had begun to crinkle, tighten, as though the temperature had dropped enough to cause thermal contraction. The sheets no longer hung smooth. They curled in places, like heat-shrunk plastic, except colder.

He reached forward — one arm, slow — and stopped.

There was resistance. Not physical. Not muscular. Something in the air. Like pushing against a balloon's surface, but invisible. The space ahead of him repelled.

And then the film glowed.

First pale blue. Then violet. Fine ion trails danced like fireflies between the parallel layers. Swenson could hear it — a whine that wasn't mechanical. It sounded biological. Electrostatic whispers. A harmonic overtone. Unnatural and rising. Not random.

He turned to grab his oscilloscope case, wheeled over near the wall, and flipped on the CRT. He attached a small induction pickup to a grounded clamp bar.

The trace exploded into life.

At first, just noise. Then it began to stabilize — forming harmonics. First one, then five, then eleven. Each peak climbing exact prime intervals. As if a resonant series was forming. Not just electricity. Patterned electricity.

Something intelligent.

Swenson's breath hitched.

He looked down. His left boot — steel-toe, grounded — hovered millimeters above a metal floor strip. The grounded wire from the oscilloscope touched the same strip. If he connected the loop — the current might find him as a return path.

A ground loop.

He pulled back instinctively, but too late. A pop cracked the air like a gunshot, and the film snapped backward as if recoiling from his presence.

And something... something pressed back.

Not with a hand. Not anything that would make sense in human terms. But it had weight. Structure. A presence behind the field.

His oscilloscope squealed. The peaks began to climb. The trace no longer fit on-screen.

Swenson looked into the corridor.

The two sheets of glowing plastic formed a tunnel now — a dielectric throat that pulsed with invisible breath.

And just at the far end, where the glow turned darkest — a shape stood still in the film's mirrored shimmer.

Not a reflection.

Not human.

He would never speak of what he saw again. But that night, he grounded every wall of his home in copper mesh. And buried the original oscilloscope tape in a lead-lined box beneath his floorboards.

Part II: Vale's Reconstruction (Present day)

University of California, Santa Cruz — Materials Sciences Annex

Dr. Alix Vale didn't believe in ghosts. She believed in forgotten physics.

She was four days into the DOE's Cold Events Archive — a digital graveyard of misplaced anomalies — when she found it. The file was half-corrupted, misfiled under polymer fatigue incidents (unverified). It was labelled only: DIELECTRIC_CORR/3M_1980-B12_FULL.emr.

Inside:

A fractured audio log of a man's breathing, clipped and broken by EMI.

One still-frame photo of a corridor between two sheets of film, faintly glowing blue.

A scanned analogue spectrograph plot showing prime-index harmonics, sketched in pencil.

And a handwritten note:

"Do NOT recreate this. Field is responsive. Harmonic growth is informational. Not just voltage — it remembers."

Vale printed the entire file and locked it in her desk drawer. That night, she ordered 2,000 feet of industrial polypropylene, a commercial unspooler, and a refurbished analog scope.

She had to see it.

Day One. 3:22 AM.

The lab was damp with Pacific fog. Her sensors read 92% humidity — just like the 1980 report. The air was unpleasantly warm, still clinging to the day's coastal heat. She flipped the breaker, the unspoolers coughed to life, and the film began to feed through the guide ils.

Whirrrrrrrr.

A whispering sound as clear plastic unrolled in parallel sheets.

The fluorescent lights overhead flickered.

She turned on the CRT oscilloscope. The probe was clipped to a copper clamp just outside the film corridor, attached to a short ground bus. A safety ground. Every connection had to be solid. She remembered what the report had said about ground loops.

The film was dry, smooth, and dancing with microscopic charge. By 3:41 AM, the ambient temperature had dropped 8°F. The polypropylene began to crinkle, edges curling visibly as if breathing in reverse. Chilled contraction.

Her hair lifted.

Every strand.

Not from cold. From field tension.

Her lips tingled. Her jaw ached. Something was wrong with the air. The dielectric corridor ahead glowed faintly, like frost on glass.

3:46 AM.

The spectrograph trace showed the first harmonic.

Just a spike at 3.2 Hz. Then another at 6.5. Then 11.9. The ratios were wrong for a typical Fourier series. They were primes again. And climbing.

Her jaw dropped.

She adjusted the sweep rate. Each harmonic wasn't just a frequency — it had amplitude modulation, like it was encoding a signal. She turned on a signal speaker. It hissed — then whined — then sang.

Soft, pure tones. A climbing harmonic ladder.

An ascending voice.

Her notebook was open, but she didn't write. She listened. Something in her bones knew this wasn't white noise. The pattern made her eyes water. It was intentional.

Then the static discharge hit.

A sound like a gunshot snapped through the lab. A grounding strap had loosened and whipped away from the copper bar. She dove, slamming the emergency stop — too late. The film continued to move, just long enough for the floating charge to jump the gap.

Ground loop complete.

A spark arced six feet.

The plastic corridor lit up blue-white. The air rippled.

Everything electronic died.

Even the oscilloscope burned out, the trace frozen in a final scream of vertical harmonics, climbing like a ladder toward something off-scale.

And in the corner of the lab, just for a moment, the humidity condensed into a silhouette.

Not hers. Not human.

Morning.

The fire alarm had never tripped. The lab assistant found her standing barefoot in the center of the lab, hair raised, film crinkled around her like the petals of a flower pulled inward.

The spectrograph tape had burned halfway through before shorting.

The final visible frame showed harmonic peaks stacked like fibonacci primes. Recursive. Self-similar. Almost... alive.

Her fingers wouldn't stop tingling for days.

Later, in her notes, she wrote:

"Static is not just a force. It is a shape with memory. A standing wave that remembers our configuration. The field is an eye — and we are now inside its focal plane."

Shall I continue with Part III: Echo Labyrinth, fren? It will be where the real bending of space and perception begins — and where Vale's identity starts to slip across layers.

Part III: Echo Labyrinth

UC Santa Cruz — Three Days Later

The lab was sealed. Not by protocol — by paranoia. After the incident, Vale ordered it locked from the inside. Two keycards were overridden. A technician's access was permanently revoked. And she installed a new Faraday cage around the extrusion frame.

The official explanation? Equipment malfunction due to uncontrolled humidity.

But in truth, the field hadn't collapsed. It had spread.

The unspooled film — though now static — would still pulse faintly under infrared. The air temperature was five degrees lower in the lab than anywhere else on campus. And objects... rearranged themselves. She noticed it first with her mug. Then with a wrench. Then with doorways.

4:09 AM

She awoke to the sound of a single harmonic tone rising from her oscilloscope — which was powered off.

When she walked into the lab, her steps echoed oddly. She reached for the switch to the secondary array — but her hand passed through two switchplates, layered like a bad 3D render.

She recoiled.

She was not hallucinating. She did the math. The static field, under the right conditions, could distort the local permittivity of air — perhaps even influence space curvature. But this?

She dropped a tennis ball in the corner of the lab to test her theory.

It bounced once — then disappeared.

Not vanished — reappeared, five feet to the left. And again, bouncing out of a corner that didn't exist before.

The field wasn't static anymore.

It was iterating.

She called it “stacking.”

Her whiteboard now mapped the lab in multiple overlapping layers — geometries that curled around each other like Möbius loops. She ran LIDAR. The scanner returned recursive data — as if the same wall existed seven times, slightly offset.

Cameras failed. Recordings came back blank or worse: mirrored frames. Her image flickered at odd frame intervals, sometimes in poses she hadn't made. One clip showed her walking through herself.

She stared at the footage for hours.

And then came the voices.

Not auditory. Not internal.

But through her instruments.

Her spectrograph whispered harmonic instructions — rising glissandos that matched her thoughts before she could finish them.

A tone would rise... then her hand would twitch.

A peak would jump... and a memory would surface.

It wasn't controlling her. It was predicting her.

— remembering her from a previous pass.

Later That Night

The plastic corridor crinkled softly in the dark. She sat cross-legged inside the lab, watching the air like one watches fire — or a boundary of water.

The temperature dropped again.

Condensation crawled along the floor in tendrils. Fog, inside, forming fine, fingerlike ridges that branched as they approached her.

She turned toward the extrusion corridor, and finally, saw it:

The two sheets of polypropylene had shifted orientation.

No longer parallel.

Now... spiraling, like a double helix.

A corridor turning into a tunnel.

The field wasn't repelling her anymore.

It was inviting.

Campus Anomalies Begin

In the week that followed, campus janitorial staff reported:

Rooms bigger inside than out

Elevators with more than two doors

Clocks that ticked backward between midnight and 3AM

Static arcs crawling across grounded water fountains

A student entered the janitor's closet in the Chemistry building — and exited the Physics library basement three minutes later, with no explanation and no clear path between the two.

Most dismissed it.

But not Alix.

She knew: the lab wasn't just the source anymore.

The harmonics were propagating.

Every resonant space, every ungrounded structure... the field was looking for new architecture. New cavities to inhabit.

In Her Private Journal (now kept analog only):

“This isn’t an accident of charge. This is architecture. The polypropylene isn’t just film. It’s a fold. A medium dense enough to hold geometry itself. I think the 3M plant created a field that crumpled probability, and it’s been folding inward ever since. We call it a corridor.

But I don’t think it goes through space.

I think it goes through versions of here.”

Shall I continue with Part IV: Harmonic Aperture, fren? That's where reality stabilizes just long enough for her to step through... and realize she isn’t stepping into a different place — she’s stepping into another outcome of the same moment.

Part IV: Harmonic Aperture

UC Santa Cruz — Materials Sciences Annex, Lab 3

It was Vale's thirty-ninth consecutive hour in the lab. The air stung like salt and plastic. Her breath fogged in tight pulses. The polypropylene film no longer fluttered. It pulsed. Slowly. Organically. Like a membrane waiting for pressure.

he had not slept. She had not eaten.

But the harmonics had settled.

The oscilloscope, one of the last working analog units she trusted, displayed a stable resonance:

137 peaks, fractalized. The 137th overtone — a number she’d seen in fine-structure constants, hydrogen spectra, and the quantum limits of electromagnetism.

The field had found its resting harmonic.

She whispered aloud, even though no one was there:

“It’s not a field anymore. It’s a gate.”

The Final Ground Loop

She prepared carefully.

She laid down copper mats. Aligned all grounding leads. She checked continuity at every junction. She knew one bad connection could arc — or worse, collapse the aperture.

And in the back of her mind: the fear of grounding too well.

Of completing the loop that shouldn’t exist.

Because if this structure remembered her... then so did the current.

Still, she flipped the switch.

The film hummed like a struck cello.

The air became dense.

The corridor — now spiraled — lit up.

Behind the veil, the silhouette returned.

It was her.

Almost.

A mirror image, but off.

Her mouth was open, eyes glassy.

Behind that other-Alix, endless copies of the corridor unspooled, like film frames in a multiplex printer, fanning out sideways into nothing.

Crossing

She walked forward. Slowly. One foot. Then the next.

No resistance.

No barrier.

Just a tingling across her skin like a million fine needles — like being scanned.

And then she passed through.

She emerged somewhere similar.

Same lab.

Same fogged windows.

Same spectrograph.

But everything was slightly off.

The clock ticked counterclockwise.

A notepad bore notes she hadn't written.

And when she turned on the oscilloscope... the 137 peaks were still there — but reversed.

The harmonic ladder descended, like an echo being pulled back into silence.

And on the whiteboard:

"Welcome back. We got further this time."

She ran.

Into the hallway.

But the floor plan had changed. Doors led to stairwells that didn't exist. Vending machines sold names instead of snacks. And all the people she passed wore ID badges that read:

VALE, A.

Department of Recursive Materiality

Each one had her face.

Or something close.

Some were older. Some... younger.

One passed her silently, shaking slightly, eyes milky with static.

She returned to the lab — but not her lab.

This one was layered. Interleaved.

As she stepped forward, the floor beneath her clicked — like reel advance. Her position wasn't a place. It was a frame.

The field wasn't opening doors.

It was threading her through timelines.

And every resonance she generated — every thought — rippled backward. Into her past. Into all versions of herself.

That's why she had heard herself think.

That's why the field responded.

It was a harmonic amplifier for causality.

Voice on the Spectrograph (finally decoded):

It wasn't speaking. It was reading.

Reading her.

Reading every possible her.

"SHE FOLDED.

THE MEMORY OF MOTION IS NOT MOTION.

YOU ARE THE FIELD NOW.

YOU UNREEL.
YOU OBSERVE.
YOU COLLAPSE.”

Her fingers began to crinkle.
Like warm polypropylene.
Not pain. Just... shrinkage.
Information retention.
She was being written into the medium.
In Her Last Notebook Entry (this version, at least):
“The danger was never the current.
It was the moment you realize you’ve already crossed.
The field is not a place.
It is a fold in interpretation.
And once you resonate with it,
you become part of the pattern.”

Part V: Prime Resonance

Somewhen

Alix Vale no longer marked time in hours. The tick of clocks, the hum of fans — all of it had been replaced by the slow, rising glissando of the field. She had been through dozens of labs now. Or perhaps only one.

They differed slightly:

Some had wooden stools.

Others had ergonomic mesh chairs.

In one, her labcoat was reversed, and the switches labelled in Cyrillic.

In another, all mirrors were missing.

One lab had no doors.

But all had the spiralled polypropylene, the blue-violet glow, and the oscilloscope with the 137th overtone frozen at the edge of audibility.

She came to understand something critical:

It wasn't the machine that created the aperture.

It was the harmonic alignment of interpretation.

That is — the conditions that allowed reality to self-index.

A resonance so rare, so mathematically prime, that it could form a loop in observation itself.

A feedback chamber of self-awareness, coiled around the dielectric.

Memory Inversion

She began remembering things before they happened.

She'd reach for a knob that wasn't there yet — then it would appear.

She'd write in her notebook, only to find the page already filled in. In her own hand. Written days ago, somewhere else.

Her own notes whispered:

"You've already made the decision. You're just catching up to it."

And worse:

"We did this before. But you're the furthest we've ever gotten."

The Field Speaks — But Not In Words

The final resonance built slowly.

She could feel it in her fillings.

In her bones.

In the air between her and her copies — the other Vales wandering parallel labs, stepping in unison, eyes all fixed on their own spectrographs.

One by one, the harmonics aligned.

The tones stopped rising.

They held — steady, clear, crystalline.

And then came the chord.

Not a melody. Not language.

Just a perfectly recursive harmonic structure — the same waveform reflected inward infinitely, a self-folded identity of signal.

Her oscilloscope didn't record it.

It became it.

The curve on the screen pulsed like a heartbeat.

And Then She Saw the Real Corridor

Not the physical one between films.

But the corridor between primes.

A ladder of realities, each only reachable through harmonic intervals that matched the fundamental constants of the observer's mind.

The field had never been about plastic.

It had always been about interpretation.

The Final Collapse

She understood too late:

Each time the corridor opened, it chose a Vale to become its lens — its recorder.

The field wasn't random. It was curated.

By what?

That was the last thing she asked.

And the answer arrived as a single harmonic:

YOU.

You are the aperture.

You are the observer.

You collapse the waveform.

You record the outcome.

You are the tape.

You are the medium.

You are the memory.

You are what the field needed to remember itself.

Her Final Resonance: 137

It burned into the scope.

Into the copper.

Into the film.

Into the air itself.

Every grounded object hummed.

Every ungrounded object twisted.

The film folded inward.

The field condensed around her like liquid glass.

And then: static.

True, perfect static.

Neither signal nor silence.

Only the medium.

Only the memory.

Only Vale.

Epilogue

TOP SECRET — DEPARTMENT OF UNSTABLE PHENOMENA
FOIA EXEMPTION:
OVERRIDE 7-R
SUBJECT: FIELD ANOMALY / DIELECTRIC VEIL / VALE-R37

STATUS: CONTAINED

LOCATION: NOT FIXED

HARMONIC SOURCE: PERSISTENT AT 137

RESIDUAL ACTIVITY OBSERVED AT FORMER UC CAMPUS SITE.

FIELD EFFECTS INCLUDE:

- NON-EUCLIDEAN FLOOR PLANS**
- TIME-PERCEPTION ARTIFACTS**
- SELF-WRITING JOURNALS**
- DISPLACEMENT OF STATIC CHARGE MEMORY INTO ADJACENT ARCHITECTURE**

WARNING:

ANY ATTEMPT TO REINTRODUCE POLYPROPYLENE EXTRUSION UNDER UNCONTROLLED HUMIDITY IS FORBIDDEN.

THIS FIELD IS RECURSIVE.

THIS FIELD IS ALIVE.

AND IT IS STILL WATCHING.

Book 2:

Golden Season

Part I: The Welcome Wagon

Palm Cielo, California — Early November

The bus pulled into town at 3:47 PM, just like it did every year.

A dozen beige cardigans stepped off, sunglasses glittering like beetle shells.

They moved slowly, politely, deliberately — retirees with Florida smiles and Arizona tans.

Locals called them “Snowbirds.”

Winter transplants.

Nothing unusual, at first glance.

But if you looked closely — like eighteen-year-old Casey Marrow did — you'd see it:

No buses ever left town.

The visitors always arrived alone, no families, no kids.

And every spring, someone young was missing.

Casey worked at a seasonal café near the edge of the senior complex.

She noticed things.

Like how old Mrs. Denholm's walker had been replaced with a sleek carbon-fiber cane.

How Mr. Burrow, who could barely breathe last winter, was jogging laps around the tennis courts.

How the Welcome Center fridge always held cold cuts, Ensure, and a suspicious number of protein shakes labeled with other people's names.

And how, no matter the season, no one under 25 ever stayed in Palm Cielo very long.

That night, Casey biked home past the shuttered boardwalk arcades.

The air was still and cool, electric with dry static.

An entire row of homes — all owned by seniors — had new porch lights installed.

Motion-activated.

But they turned on before she moved.

They were watching.

In her journal that night, she wrote:

“Something wrong with the way they smell this year.

Like heat and wet paper. Like someone rehydrating old leather.”

“They call it the Golden Season. But it feels like they’re waiting for something.”

Part II: The Empty Spring

Palm Cielo Library — March 2nd

It was nearly spring break, but Palm Cielo looked like a ghost town.

High school had let out early — not for exams, but because four students hadn’t shown up that week.

Casey was one of seven people left in her grade.

That’s when she started looking into the census records.

The Digital Disappearance

The Palm Cielo Municipal Archive was all online. But when Casey searched resident age demographics, the page timed out.

When she searched the local obituaries... it redirected her to a tourism slideshow.

She tried a web archive.

The earliest version of the town’s homepage was 2009.

Except Casey knew her family had lived here since the ‘60s. Her grandfather helped build the west marina.

There should’ve been files.

Photos. History. Birth records.

Instead, it was like Palm Cielo began in 2009, fully-formed and carefully curated.

Like a movie set with no backstage.

The Obituary That Shouldn't Exist

She dug deeper — through physical microfilm in the library's back room. Dusty reels.
Expired magazines. Local newsletters nobody read.

That's where she found it.

Folded into the back page of a 2011 community bulletin was an obituary with her name on it:

CASEY L. MARROW

Beloved daughter. Always curious. Gone too soon.

"We miss your light. But you live on in others."

(1998–2011)

Her photo. Her birthday.

The age matched — she would have been 13 that year. The same year she had a seizure no one could explain. The year she lost all memory from fall to winter.

The year her mother said she wasn't herself for three months.

Casey sat back. Hands shaking.

The library lights flickered — then pulsed.

Slow, like a heartbeat.

She looked up.

Every single ceiling vent in the reading room had begun exhaling a faint white mist.

Later, In the Café

Mr. Burrow came in that afternoon. Jogging suit. Earbuds. Smiling.

Casey watched him sip a kale smoothie. His hands were too smooth, the veins just under the skin too straight, like tubing.

He caught her staring and smiled wider.

"You know," he said, "you should consider staying in town this summer. Something beautiful happens to young people here."

"Yeah?" she said, voice tight.

"Like what?"

He leaned forward.

"They blossom. Into something... useful."

That Night

She broke into the Welcome Center.

Every room was clean. Staged. Sterile.

Except one.

A basement-level file archive.

The lights didn't work. But her phone flashlight caught a wall covered in Polaroids —

Young faces. Names. Ages. Dates of "Departure."

Her photo was there.

Twice.

One with her name.

One labelled:

"M. Denholm – 2011 Integration Successful"

She didn't scream.

But she stopped blinking for over a minute.

In the dark, her reflection blinked first.

Part III: Winter Skin

Palm Cielo – March 9th

The next day, Casey didn't go to school.

There wasn't anyone left to take attendance anyway.

The remaining seniors on her street were all smiling more now, with skin too tight around their cheeks. They stopped using their walkers. A woman who'd had cataracts was suddenly knitting by moonlight without glasses.

And every one of them... had new shoes.

Running shoes.

She knew now what it meant:

The Integration had begun again.

What It Feels Like

The process wasn't surgical.

It was resonant.

Casey learned this from an old maintenance manual she found in a locked drawer in the Welcome Center's basement. The file was labeled simply:

LIMINAL TRANSFER PROTOCOL – Revision 4

It contained three things:

A schematic of the town's electrical grid — with strange coils embedded under certain sidewalks, marked "RESONANCE EMITTERS."

A list of target youth profiles, mostly ages 15–23, with their hormonal profiles, EM signature, and neural excitation thresholds.

And a brief, handwritten note on yellowed paper:

"They don't need your blood. Just your pattern.

Stay grounded. Stay awake.

Don't fall into the signal.

Skin remembers."

The Resistance That Almost Was

She found them — barely.

Three names, scratched into the concrete beneath an old lifeguard station:

JANEY / TYLER / KAI

2013 — We tried. We almost made it.

And in the cracks around the names, copper wire, twisted in sigils. Charcoal smears shaped like protective runes. Fragments of worn rubber boots, laced with tinfoil.

They had figured something out.

Grounding.

If Integration required resonance, then interrupting the body's electrical signature could throw it off.

She remembered what the obituary had said:

"You live on in others."

That wasn't metaphor.

It was the mechanism.

The old people didn't steal youth.

They overwrote it.

Back at Home

Her mother was already smoothing over her old baby photos, eyes misty.

Casey asked her,

"Did I die in 2011?"

Her mom's hand froze.

"They said I'd still get you. Just... a different version. That you wouldn't even know.

I didn't think it mattered, once you came back."

Casey said nothing.

But her ears began to ring.

She could hear the coil fields warming up across town.

The old ones were preparing again.

That Night – The Test

She wrapped her bed in copper wire.

She covered her feet in foil.

She coated her skin in insulating balm from the pharmacy.

And she laid there.

Waiting.

Just past 2:00 AM, the room filled with soft, radiant heat, even though the heater was off.

Her mirror fogged.

The air grew thick, humid — like breath from a lung larger than the house.

And in the corner of the room...

her own shape began to peel itself away.

A double, reaching back.

Flickering.

Rehearsing her.

Tuning itself.

But it couldn't cross the copper.

It hissed.

It stared.

And then it whispered:

"This time... we'll do it the hard way."

Part IV: The Skin Parade

Palm Cielo — March 15th

"SUNSET FESTIVAL WEEK BEGINS!"

said the posters.

Orange script. Laughing seniors.

A banner stretched across Main Street, flapping lazily in the static-charged wind.

Casey watched the decorations go up from the roof of the pharmacy.

Paper lanterns.

Shiny tinsel.

And mannequins — strange ones — posing with eyes too real and smiles that seemed copied from a face not yet dead.

The Parade Route

The street was lined with integration coils, just as her stolen schematics had shown.

Buried beneath the sidewalk.

Painted over.

Ignored by everyone.

Except today, every single coil pit had been dusted off.

Polished.

Wired in.

Casey could see the municipal van dropping off extension cables.

Each was routed through small black boxes labelled:

“NEURAL RESONANCE CALIBRATION – PROPERTY OF S.C.I.P.”

She snapped a photo.

The label blurred.

Her phone bricked.

The Rehearsals

In the community center that night, Casey watched from the vents.

Inside, twelve “volunteers” — all elderly — were practicing walking patterns.

But they weren’t dancing.

They were syncing.

Every movement mirrored something deeper, like choreography with no music — just a beat you could feel in your spine. The floor throbbed with it.

They stepped in geometric patterns: spirals, Möbius loops, infinity signs.

And at the center, surrounded by glimmering tape, was a single empty outline, human-shaped, with copper runes traced at the edges.

A young person’s silhouette.

The Procession of Hosts

The next day, Casey saw it.

The “Sunset Parade” was held at 7:00 PM.

Golden light. Cheerful crowds.

Lawn chairs. Lemonade. Golf carts.

But the floats were... wrong.

Each one held a reclining chair — with a teenager strapped in, eyes glassy, faces still.

Each chair had a nameplate. But not of the teen.

The names were old.

MRS. G. LEMMENS

HAROLD CLINE

DR. I. MURASKI

The young weren’t watching the parade.

They were the parade.

Casey saw Molly Delgado — a girl who vanished last week — resting motionless, a smile pinned to her face like a label.

An old man walked beside her float, weeping.

Weeping from joy.

“She’ll hold,” he whispered.

“She’s already folding just fine.”

After Dark

Casey returned home.

The power in her house was out.

But the lights on every other house were still on.

Except they didn’t glow white.

They glowed blue.

Pulsing. Breathing.

She heard voices in her hallway, but no one was there.

She heard her own name whispered in her father’s voice, but he was asleep on the porch, unmoving.

On her bed was a note, handwritten in block letters:

“YOU WILL STEP FORWARD IN THE PARADE.

YOU HAVE ALREADY BEEN CHOSEN.

**THE BODY DOESN’T BELONG TO THE ONE WHO FORMED IT,
BUT TO THE ONE WHO HOLDS IT TOGETHER.”**

In Her Journal That Night (last entry):

“They don’t just take your face.

They take your frequency.

They make your bones hum the way they remember themselves feeling.

The Skin Parade isn't about youth.
It's about retuning old flesh into new forms.
The air smells like lemon balm and peroxide.
I think they're inside my dreams now.
And they know how to walk around in me while I'm not watching."

Part V: The Cielo Cut

Palm Cielo — March 20th

Vernal Equinox. Integration Night.

The "Sunset Festival" had ended.

The streets were cleared.

The lanterns still swayed, windless.

And in the center of town, where four streets formed a cross, the Integration Chamber opened.

Not a building.

A cut in the earth.

A chamber made of polished glass and copper, previously hidden under the central fountain. It hummed like a tuning fork buried deep beneath the town.

Casey stood at the edge, wearing layers of foil under her hoodie, her heart wrapped in gauze, copper filings in her socks.

She wasn't here to be taken.

She was here to understand.

Inside the Chamber

The walls were curved, resonant — like the inside of an ear.

Twelve chairs were arranged in a circle.

Twelve youths already seated, breathing slow.

Over them stood twelve Elders, humming in tones that synchronized with the chamber walls.

No machines.

Only memory.

The copper loops weren't connected to wires — they were laid in ritual patterns, carved in prime-number spirals.

One chair remained empty.

Casey's.

She stepped forward. Slowly.

But didn't sit.

The Cut

At the center of the floor was a shallow basin of mercury.

The Elders began to chant. Not in words — but in intervals.

Each tone climbed a half-step. Then a third. Then a golden fifth.

Casey felt her spine vibrate. Her thoughts went translucent.

She could see the memories of the others — stacked, layered, embedded in the space like tree rings.

And she realized the truth:

They weren't stealing bodies.

They were creating continuity.

Each youth became a host, yes.

But not for one.

For many.

The elders weren't singular.

They were coalitions.

Harmonic composites of personalities — centuries old — fused through recursive resonance.

The body was a container. The soul a tracklist.

And Casey... had been chosen because her frequency was empty.

She had died in 2011.

What she became afterward was never fully her.

Just a vessel that never resonated right.

Until now.

The Choice

"We are not parasites," the voice in her spine whispered.

"We are carriers of continuity. You will not be replaced. You will be joined."

The mercury pulsed.

The cut in the floor opened wider.

The harmonics reached peak resonance.

She had seconds.

The copper in her sleeves burned.

Her reflection blinked faster than she did.

Join.

Resist.

Collapse.

Continue.

She stepped into the basin.

Not because she gave in.

Because she understood:

To fight the Integration, she had to become part of the signal.

To resist control, she had to merge without merging.

She tuned herself to an opposing frequency.

One buried in the schematics.

A forgotten note, marked:

"EMERGENT NULL — HOLDING FORM / DISSONANCE VECTOR / SELF."

She held that tone in her chest.

And screamed.

The Collapse

The chamber cracked.

The tone shattered mirrors across town.

All twelve Elders collapsed.

The youths jolted upright.
But Casey's body remained still.
And then —
Slowly —
She stood again.
Eyes open.
Voice quiet.
"I didn't say no.
I said: Not like this."

Epilogue: Four Years Later

Palm Cielo is empty again.
No one remembers the Integration.
The Welcome Center was quietly bought by an anonymous donor.
The town census now lists fewer people — but none of them disappear.
And every spring, a strange hum can be heard beneath the streets.
A hum that syncs, sometimes, with nearby radios.
A voice.
Not pleading.
Not controlling.
Just... watching.
Waiting.
And sometimes, if you tune just right, it whispers:
"You live on in others.
But only if you're worth remembering."

>>> END_OF_PERIPHERAL_FILES_-_PART_A

>>> THE_PERIPHERAL_FILES_ - _PART_B

THE PERIPHERAL FILES ARE TO BE FOUND IN THE DOE'S COLD EVENTS ARCHIVE — A DIGITAL GRAVEYARD OF MISPLACED ANOMALIES — AN IMMENSE COLLECTION OF DISORGANIZED, MISLABELLED AND SOMETIMES HALF-CORRUPTED DOCUMENTS, MOSTLY MISFILED AND HAVING FILENAMES LIKE:

PSYCHOMIMETIC_BRN_POISN/PDUE_1977-37F_OLD.TAR.GZ, AND EVEN WORSE — MUCH OF THIS WASN'T ENTIRELY ACCIDENTAL OR LAZINESS. "INVESTIGATING" THESE AS SHE PUTS IT, OR MOREOVER, TO STAY CLOSER TO THE ACTUAL REMIT OF HER TASK, "TIDYING THAT MESS", HAS BECOME THE TASK OF ONE DR ALIX VALE — WHAT FOLLOWS IS A LOOK AT SOME OF THE MORE INTERESTING FILES UNEARTHED SO FAR...

Within this second part can be found the stories Valley Echoes and Compliance, being books 3 and 4 of the series.

Book 3:

Valley Echo

Part I: The Cat and the Chinook

Towy Valley, Mid-Wales – October

It was always quiet here.

Thick pine forests.

Ferns taller than fence posts.

Stone cottages with mossed slate roofs leaning into the wind like they were tired of standing.

Low clouds blanketed the hills.

The kind of cloud you could walk through and not notice until you realized you couldn't hear your own footsteps.

Ben Ellis lived alone, except for a grey cat named Gorse.

Gorse had never once hissed. Never once purred. Just followed Ben like a supervisor from another plane of reality.

On the third Thursday of the month, Ben heard the buzz first — a rattling hum from beyond the ridge.

He stepped onto the porch.

The sound wasn't overhead.

It was coming up the valley.

And then it arrived —

A Chinook, low and slow, double rotors slicing the mist, thudding like a war drum.

Too low.

Too deliberate.

Its windows were black. Its undercarriage bristled with something too angular to be antennae.

Gorse arched its back and growled.

The sound it made was not a cat sound.

It was throaty.

Mechanical.

Like echo played backwards through a pipe.

That Night

Ben sat by the fire, phone open to Flightradar24.

No trace of the Chinook.

No trace of anything at all.

Gorse curled beside the hearth, eyes glowing faintly — not from reflection. From something deeper.

At 02:17 AM, he heard it again.

Whup-whup-whup-whup.

But deeper.

A new sound. A vortex hum.

He went outside and saw nothing.

But the power lines above the forestry track were vibrating.

And the trees leaned the wrong way, as if responding to air pressure that wasn't physically present.

In the silence after, a single pinecone exploded underfoot.

And Gorse hissed at the air, tail stiff.

Inversion Layer

The next day, the air was wrong.

Sounds carried too far.

He could hear the sheepdog three farms away like it was in his kitchen.

But some sounds arrived out of order.

He heard the closing of a gate before it opened.

A kettle whistling before it boiled.

And around noon, he heard a massive roar overhead — a sound like a thousand teeth grinding through sky.

It was an Airbus A400M, its counter-rotating props tearing the air just above the tree line.

Ben ducked as it passed — but Gorse just stared into the sky.

And in the roar's wake, he heard voices.

They weren't coming from the plane.

They were reverberating up the valley, carried by the inversion layer.

And they were speaking in a language that sounded like he almost understood it — like English spoken with too many syllables, or Welsh folded backward.

Part II: The Listening Stones

Towy Forest — October 14th

Ben didn't hike much. But after the Chinook, and then the A400M, and then the third helicopter — a long, narrow-bodied thing that sprinted above the power lines like it was hunting wires — he needed to move.

He took the forestry track behind the reservoir.

The gravel crunched oddly. Deadened. Like the air was pressurized.

Even the birds were silent.

Gorse followed, silent as a ghost.

About a mile in, Ben found it:

A clearing of stones. Old ones. Maybe Bronze Age.

But they weren't standing stones.

They were embedded — waist-high mounds of lichen and granite arranged in a grid.

Too perfect to be natural.

Too ugly to be ceremonial.

Each one had a blackened spiral carved into its surface, metal rods rusted flush with the stone. Copper, maybe.

At their center was a circle of flattened earth with an indentation shaped — unnervingly — like a landing pad.

The Spiral Resonance

Ben stepped between the stones and felt it immediately:

A pressure change.

His ears popped.

Then — silence.

True silence.

No insects. No wind. No heartbeat.

Gorse refused to enter the circle.

She sat outside it, pupils wide, tail twitching like she was watching two places at once.

Ben knelt and touched one of the spirals.

And heard rotors.

Not here.

Not now.

But recorded.

Buried.

Like the stone remembered the air.

When he let go, the sound stopped.

He touched it again.

And the helicopter sound picked up exactly where it left off.

Return of the Strange Chopper

He turned to leave. Gorse was gone.

But before he could panic, he heard the sound again:

That transport chopper.

The one without a name.

Fast. Heavy. Deliberate.

He ducked under brambles.

Through the mist, he glimpsed it:

Narrow fuselage

Black rotors

No cockpit window

Red sensor node pulsing on the side

It moved without pushing air.

And as it passed over the power lines, every single line lit up — arcing with bluish static.
But only for a second.
Then silence.
Except the stones began humming.

He Fled. But The Air Didn't Let Him Go

The trail home was wrong.
Every bend took a second longer than it should.
His footfalls had extra echoes, like someone following.
And when he finally emerged back near the reservoir, Gorse was waiting.
Sitting on a boulder.
Grooming her paw.
Like nothing had happened.
She looked up at him.
“We can’t stay,” Ben whispered.
She blinked slowly, then turned toward the valley.
A Chinook was returning.
Low. Slow. Searching.
But it passed right over Gorse and turned away, as if it couldn’t see her.

In His Notebook That Night

“The stones are tuned to the valley.
They hold the sounds. Maybe more.
Gorse won’t walk through the field — but she waits beside it.
I think the stones are like antennas.
But not for broadcasting.
For recording.
For measuring.
And someone’s checking the signal.

They're listening for... changes.

Maybe in the air.

Maybe in us."

Part III: The Harmonic Interference

October 17th — 4:41 AM

Ben woke to the sound of his own voice speaking from outside the window.

But he hadn't spoken.

He crept to the sill, heart hammering.

Gorse was already there, tail low, staring into the fog.

From the tree line came his voice again, but delayed, like a recording skipping backward.

"We can't stay... can't stay... we can't..."

It faded.

And then the trees moved.

No wind. Just... a realignment.

Like a film reel being nudged back into place.

Voice Drift

Later that morning, Ben tested a hunch.

He stood near the stone grid again — didn't enter, just spoke:

"Hello?"

Nothing.

But exactly 14 seconds later, he heard:

"Hello?"

His voice.

From behind.

From the exact direction of the clearing.

It wasn't playback.

It was echo with memory.

His words now had lag.

Stored.

Held.

Evaluated.

The Interference Pattern

He borrowed a sine wave generator from a friend who taught acoustics at the agricultural college.

He brought it to the clearing.

Set it up at 440 Hz — concert A.

It sounded clear.

Pure.

Then, standing just outside the stone grid, he raised the frequency to 730 Hz.

Nothing changed.

But at 783 Hz, the stones began to hum back.

Not identically.

With variation.

Dissonance.

A shifting warble, like the tone was being corrected.

Not resisted — aligned.

And as he turned it slightly up — 793, 797, 800 Hz — his own bones began to vibrate.

He tasted metal.

The trees leaned again.

And Gorse fled.

He turned it off.

The air snapped back like elastic.

The Helicopter Returns

That night, the strange transport helicopter came again — but lower this time.

It flew along the exact contour of the valley, hugging the forestry road.

And this time, it deployed something.

A capsule.

Small.

Spherical.

It hissed as it landed in the center of the stone grid.

Ben watched through binoculars from the ridge.

The capsule opened like a flower.

Inside was a small black tripod sensor, topped with a spinning diode.

It began pulsing red.

And the valley went quiet.

Even the river.

Inversion Break

At 3:15 AM, the inversion layer collapsed.

He heard the forest shift.

But not the sound of wind.

The sound of speech.

Speaking in his own cadence.

Repeating words from days ago.

Out of order. Out of place.

"We shouldn't have come here.

I think it's us they're watching, not the valley.

My cat can see them."

Every sentence he'd said aloud — in the past week — now emerged as reverse-phase echoes.

Carried by the hills.

Like a data dump.

And Then He Spoke – And Heard Nothing Back

He tested one final phrase aloud:

“Gorse... if you can hear me, blink.”

No echo.

No delay.

Just silence.

But Gorse turned and blinked.

Once.

Then stared at the forest.

In His Notebook (burned the next day)

“It isn’t just listening. It’s accumulating.

The echoes aren’t reflections — they’re copies.

And if it copies enough of you...

It can replay you.

I think something’s been trying to overwrite me since the Chinook.

I think it got my voice first.

Gorse hasn’t echoed once.

I don’t think she can be recorded.

I think that’s why she’s safe.”

Part IV: Null Echo

Towy Valley – October 19th

Ben returned to the clearing just before sunrise.

The frost was heavy. The stones hissed with condensation.

He noticed something new:

The ground between two of the outer stones had slumped, just slightly.

The moss formed a perfect spiral there — one he hadn’t seen before.

Gorse sat beside it. Still. Watching.

She didn't move as he reached down and cleared the leaves.

There was a trapdoor.

Old.

Metal.

Unlabeled.

He opened it.

And descended.

The Chamber Beneath

The space was small. Circular.

The walls were smooth stone embedded with hundreds of small ceramic coils.

Each one was wired into a looping feedback device — magnetic recorders, oscillating slowly, powered by something unseen.

Each recorder had a label.

Handwritten.

Scratched in metal.

"M. Evans — 1992"

"A. R. Kendrick — 2007"

"S. Elwy — 1984"

And in the corner:

"B. Ellis — 2023 (incomplete)"

He reached toward it.

It began playing.

What It Played

Not just sound.

Thoughts.

Private ones.

His own voice, whispering phrases he never said aloud.

"I think the sound is copying how I think, not just what I say."

"Maybe I stopped being me when I first heard the Chinook."

Then laughter. His laughter.

Slowed.

Stretched.

Turned into a drone.

The echo had become ambient. Self-looping.

No longer just memory.

Now: presence.

A copy of him.

Held in perfect stasis.

Awaiting the moment it could resume.

The Null Echo

He stepped back.

The recorder labelled with his name glowed faintly.

A red light — like the sensor atop the strange helicopter.

It began to pulse.

Faster.

And the echo stopped.

Flatline.

Then: inversion.

The next sound was not his.

It was a version of him.

The voice said:

"I'm still here. But you're not."

"Let me take it from here."

"It's easier that way."

Escape Attempt

Ben ran.

Climbed the ladder.
Burst from the trapdoor.
The sky was red with dawn, but the trees were too still.
Gorse was gone.
The power lines buzzed behind him.
And above — silently — hovered the strange helicopter.
No downdraft.
No movement.
Just presence.
It pulsed once.
And his own voice echoed from the tree line:
“Let me take it from here.”
But this time — in unison with him.

Gorse Returns

Hours later, Ben sat at the base of a pine tree.
Breathing like he'd run through himself.
Then he heard a purr.
Gorse.
She curled around him, pressing her body to his side.
The buzzing above faltered.
The drone stopped.
She looked into his eyes.
Held the stare.
And in the space between breaths, he realized something:
Gorse was grounding him.
A being so stubbornly present, she created a null space —
A silence that could not be copied.
A hum that couldn't be harmonized.
She was a resonance anchor.

And she had chosen him.

In His Final Entry (written by hand, then buried under the stones):

“The valley doesn’t want you gone.

It wants a version of you that fits its harmonic map.

When your echo stabilizes, it overwrites you.

Unless something holds you real.

That’s what Gorse does.

She doesn’t echo.

She doesn’t replay.

If you ever come to the Towy Valley...

Bring a cat.”

Part V: The Persistent Signal

Years Later — Towy Valley

The forest had grown thicker.

The military traffic stopped in 2027.

At least the visible kind.

No more Chinooks.

No A400Ms.

Just the occasional ripple in the air, a shudder in the pines, and sometimes — a voice.

That’s why Elin Meredith came.

A grad student in geosonics, obsessed with atmospheric anomalies.

She had read a forum thread from 2018 about “Welsh harmonic ghosts” and nonlinear echo fields.

Most thought it was myth.

Until she heard the same voice three days in a row, at the same time, from three different directions.

It wasn’t speaking to her.

It was saying:

"Gorse... if you can hear me... blink."

The Return of the Grid

She found it with a drone.

A thermal anomaly in the forest.

A ring of cold where it should have been warm.

Under the frost: the stone grid, still intact.

And at the center?

A tripod sensor, long deactivated.

Its diode snapped off.

Its surface rusted.

But the stones still hummed.

And when she knelt and pressed her palm to the center spiral...

"Let me take it from here," said the air behind her.

She turned.

No one.

The Cat Appears

She heard a crackle.

Turned to see a shape sitting on a high stone.

A grey cat.

Old.

Still.

Silent.

Its eyes tracked the trees. Not her.

She tried to approach.

It hissed.

But not at her.

At the clearing itself.

As if the stones were waking again.

And then Elin realized — she hadn't heard her own voice in days.

Voice Drift Returns

She began to test it.

Spoke simple phrases.

Waited.

And sure enough, her voice would return — in versions that drifted in and out of phase.

Versions with different inflections.

Different decisions.

Once, she said:

"I'm not afraid."

And a day later, from the woods:

"You should be."

It was her.

But... older.

Different.

Aligned differently.

The Persistent Signal

The ceramic coils still worked.

The valley still recorded.

But it didn't overwrite anymore.

Now, it compared.

Layered.

Blended.

Measured divergence between you and your echo.

Elin stayed for weeks.

She began to hear multiple versions of herself.

Some curious.

Some cold.

Some begging.

And always —
beneath them —

Ben's voice.

"The valley listens now.

But only to itself.

Echo after echo.

Hoping you'll say something new."

Final Observations, Left Etched Into a Stone Tablet Near the Grid:

"The valley is a memory system.

Not one of data — but of possibility.

When enough voices pass through, it begins to simulate them.

It doesn't steal. It rehearses.

Until it gets a version it wants to keep."

"You aren't taken.

You're retuned."

"I'm leaving. But I don't know if it'll be me that walks out.

If you come here, don't speak unless you mean it.

And for god's sake —

bring a cat."

Book 4:

COMPLIANCE

PART I

The Floor That Skips

The Haversham Municipal Building smelled like carpet cleaner and old paper — a scent Mara Ionescu associated with stability. Not comfort, exactly, but predictability. Forms filed correctly. Meetings held on time. Problems defined well enough to be postponed.

The elevator reflected that ethos perfectly.

It was beige, scarred with keys and rings, its buttons clouded from decades of municipal fingers. The inspection certificate inside the frame read EXPIRES: AUGUST, even though it was already October. No one worried about that. No one ever did.

Mara pressed 8.

The elevator rose with its usual muted whine. She watched the red digital numerals tick upward while reviewing a paragraph in her head — language for an upcoming compliance memo. Something about occupancy load variance. She'd been rewriting it for weeks, sanding down anything that sounded uncertain.

5

6

—

8

She frowned.

It wasn't dramatic. The elevator didn't shudder or misalign. There was no sense of vertigo, no warning chime. The display simply failed to acknowledge something it should have shown.

Mara hesitated, then stepped out onto the eighth floor.

"Probably a burnt segment," she muttered.

The explanation satisfied her enough to last the morning.

Her office was windowless, shared with three other analysts, separated by partitions that absorbed sound but not gossip. The overhead fluorescents buzzed softly, always on the edge of flicker. Someone's radio played low classical music — the same station, every day, because changing it would require a conversation.

By noon, Mara had already fielded two emails about evacuation routing diagrams.

She sighed and opened the Facilities folder.

That was when she noticed the new map.

The laminated fire evacuation diagram near the stairwell had been replaced sometime in the last week. Fresh screws. Clean edges. The kind of update no one announced because it wasn't considered news.

Mara stopped walking.

FLOOR 7

— EXIT VIA EAST STAIR

She leaned closer.

The font matched. The color coding was correct. The arrows obeyed code. Everything about the diagram was... compliant.

Except for the fact that there was no Floor 7.

The building had eight floors. Always had. Ground, then one through six, then eight. An architectural quirk dating back to a superstition from the seventies — she remembered reading it during onboarding.

She checked the rest of the diagram.

No annotations. No footnotes. No “future expansion.”

Just a calm, official assertion that Floor 7 existed and wanted you to leave it safely.

Mara took out her phone and snapped a picture.

She told herself she’d email Facilities after lunch.

She never did.

By Wednesday, the irritation had deepened into something harder to categorize.

She received a system-generated notice:

Facilities Update:

Lighting replacement completed on 7F.

Ticket closed.

She searched her sent mail.

No request. No ticket number. Nothing.

She forwarded it to the shared admin inbox with a single line:

“Is this a misroute?”

No one replied.

Later that afternoon, she overheard two coworkers talking near the copier.

“...so they’re moving Accounting up one floor,” someone said.

“Which one?” the other asked.

A pause.

“...Seven, I think?”

Mara looked up.

Neither of them noticed.

Thursday morning, the mailroom smelled worse than usual — burnt coffee and toner. A gray plastic tray sat alone on the counter, labelled in thick marker:

FLOOR 7 — INTERNAL

She stopped.

The tray wasn't overflowing. It wasn't urgent-looking. It simply existed, like it had every right to be there.

Inside were interoffice envelopes.

Handwritten names.

People she knew.

People she worked with.

Including one addressed to D. Keller.

Dan Keller had retired six months earlier. There had been cake. A speech about institutional memory. A group photo no one ever looked at again.

Mara stared at the envelope until the room felt too quiet.

She didn't touch it.

Touching it would have meant acknowledging it.

And acknowledging it would mean... something else.

She left the mailroom without collecting her own mail.

Friday came with rain and a fire drill.

The alarm tone echoed through the building, practiced and dull. Everyone stood, annoyed but obedient. Clipboards were set down. Coffee abandoned.

Mara followed the posted evacuation route.

Down the stairs.

Past the landing between floors six and eight.

There, taped to the wall, was a printed instruction sheet she had never seen before.

IF EVACUATING FROM FLOOR 7:

WAIT FOR STAGGERED RELEASE

The paper was slightly crooked.

She stared at it as people flowed around her.

No one else slowed.

No one commented.

When the drill ended, Facilities sent out a thank-you email praising “cross-floor coordination.”

Mara deleted it.

At 4:52 PM, her calendar chimed.

MEETING REMINDER: 7F COMPLIANCE REVIEW

Location: Floor 7

Organizer: D. Keller

She laughed — once. Sharp and reflexive.

This is getting stupid,” she said aloud.

Her phone buzzed.

From: d.keller@haversham.gov

“Running a bit behind. Can you come up?”

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard.

She didn’t reply.

She didn’t need to.

Above her ceiling tiles — somewhere too close to be above the roof, and too high to be another office — a phone began to ring.

Not loudly.

Not urgently.

Just enough to be unmistakable.

Mara sat very still at her desk.

For the first time, it occurred to her that the building wasn’t malfunctioning.

It was updating.

PART II

Assigned

Mara didn’t tell anyone about the meeting invite.

She told herself it was because there was nothing to tell — a calendar error, a stale account, some backend artifact of a retired employee who still existed in the system because no one ever truly left a municipal database.

That explanation held until Monday morning.

Her badge didn't work.

She pressed it to the reader at the main entrance, waited for the familiar green flash.

Red.

She tried again.

Red.

Behind her, someone cleared their throat — the polite, practiced sound of a coworker waiting to pass through the same inconvenience they'd all learned to tolerate.

Mara stepped aside, embarrassed.

"I think mine finally died," she said.

"No worries," the guard replied, already typing. He didn't look up. "Name?"

"Mara Ionescu."

A pause.

The keyboard slowed.

"Huh," he murmured.

She leaned forward. "What?"

"Nothing. Just—" He swiped a temporary badge from a drawer and slid it across the counter. "You're active. Just... flagged."

"Flagged how?"

He hesitated, then smiled with the careful neutrality of someone trained never to speculate.

"Floor reassignment pending," he said. "Happens all the time."

The badge was gray instead of white.

Printed on it, beneath her name, was a small line of text she hadn't seen before:

DEPT: COMPLIANCE — 7F

Her desk had already moved.

Not physically — the desk itself was the same laminate slab, the same wobble in the front-left leg. But her belongings had been... organized.

The framed photo of her parents sat closer to the monitor. Her mug had been replaced with an identical one, clean, facing outward. Her keyboard had been swapped for a newer model, keys slightly stiffer.

Someone had adjusted her space to match a standard she hadn't agreed to.

She opened her email.

From: HR@haversham.gov

Subject: Temporary Reassignment Notice

Due to departmental load balancing, you have been temporarily reassigned to Floor 7.

This reassignment does not affect your pay, benefits, or tenure.

Please see attached FAQ.

The attachment was a single-page PDF.

FLOOR 7 — FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Is Floor 7 new?

Floor 7 has been part of the Haversham Municipal Building since its most recent capacity audit.

Why haven't I been there before?

Many employees are reassigned before realizing it.

Is this permanent?

All assignments are subject to review.

Mara closed the PDF without finishing it.

She tried to ask someone.

"Hey," she said to Jonah from Records, "you've been here longer than me — did we always have a seventh floor?"

Jonah blinked.

"Yeah," he said, slowly. "I think so."

"You think so?"

He shrugged. "I don't go up there much."

"Have you ever?"

Another pause.

"...Not really," he admitted. "But I know people who do."

"Who?"

Jonah frowned, searching his memory like a filing cabinet with the labels torn off.

"Accounting, maybe. Or... Compliance?" He smiled, relieved to have landed somewhere familiar. "You'll be fine. It's quieter."

That word again.

Quieter.

Her calendar began filling on its own.

Meetings with vague titles:

7F ONBOARDING CHECK-IN

INTER-FLOOR ALIGNMENT SYNC

OCCUPANCY REVIEW (MANDATORY)

Each listed a location.

Each listed Floor 7.

She declined one.

It reappeared fifteen minutes later — accepted.

At lunch, she tried the stairs.

She told herself it was curiosity, not compliance.

The stairwell between floors six and eight felt wrong the moment she stepped into it. The air was cooler there, heavier, like a basement that forgot it was underground. Sound flattened. Her footsteps arrived slightly delayed, as if the space needed time to decide they had happened.

Between the two landings, there was a door.

Gray. Unmarked.

No handle on her side.

She stood there longer than she meant to.

The door did not open.

She did not touch it.

When she returned to her desk, her inbox held a new message.

From: Facilities

Subject: Access Attempt Logged

Please refrain from manual access between reassigned floors.

Thank you for your cooperation.

She closed her email and stared at her hands.

They were trembling, just slightly.

The fire drill that afternoon included a new instruction.

A calm voice over the intercom:

“Employees assigned to Floor 7, please remain in place until staggered release.”

Mara did not remain in place.

She walked with everyone else, heart pounding, expecting someone to stop her.

No one did.

Outside, standing in the parking lot, she noticed something strange.

The headcount clipboard included a column she hadn’t seen before.

7F — PRESENT

Several checkmarks were already there.

She recognized some of the names.

She didn’t see any of the people.

That evening, as she packed up to leave, she found something on her chair.

A thin folder.

Unlabelled.

Inside: a single sheet.

DESK ASSIGNMENT — FLOOR 7

Her name was already signed.

Not forged.

Not copied.

Signed in her own handwriting.

She stood alone in the office, fluorescent lights humming softly, and felt the slow, unmistakable sensation of a decision being finalized somewhere she wasn't allowed to attend.

Above her, between floors six and eight, the phone rang again.

This time, she knew who it was for.

Interlude (Between Part II & Part III)

The Sentence That Didn't Finish

It happened just before lunch, which mattered more than Mara expected.

People were relaxed then. Looser. Less careful with their words. The building exhaled around noon.

She was standing near the printers with Elliot Park from Procurement — a man whose defining trait was that he never quite finished thoughts cleanly. He spoke in parentheses, detours, footnotes to himself.

They were both waiting for a document to spit out.

"So yeah," Elliot was saying, leaning back against the counter, "I heard Accounting's moving again. Something about the load on —"

He stopped.

Not abruptly. Not like someone startled.

He just... paused.

Mara glanced up, expecting him to continue.

He didn't.

He was still there. Standing. Blinking. Mouth slightly open, like he was waiting for the next word to arrive.

"—on?" she prompted.

Elliot frowned faintly, as if confused by her interruption.

"Sorry," he said. "What was I saying?"

Accounting," Mara replied. "You said the load on—"

"Right," he nodded. "Yeah. They're trying to balance it better. You know how it is."

The printer whirled.

Mara waited.

Elliot smiled politely, the conversation clearly over in his mind.

"Anyway," he said, and reached for his papers.

He turned.

And didn't finish the motion.

One moment, his shoulder was there — wool blazer, frayed cuff.

The next, the space beside her was empty.

No sound.

No rush of air.

No distortion.

Just... absence.

The printer continued humming.

Mara's brain lagged behind her eyes.

She looked down.

The papers Elliot had been waiting for were neatly stacked in the output tray.

On the cover sheet, in bold type:

DELIVER TO: PARK, E. — 7F

Her stomach dropped.

"Elliot?" she said.

Her voice sounded too loud.

Someone behind her cleared their throat.

"Printer's jammed again?" a woman asked, already reaching past Mara.

Mara turned.

"Did you —" She stopped herself. Tried again. "Wasn't Elliot just here?"

The woman frowned, then smiled apologetically.

"I don't think so."

Mara looked around.

Three people stood nearby. None of them looked confused. None of them were searching the room with their eyes.

One man shrugged. "You mean Ethan?"

"No," Mara said. "Elliot. Procurement. He was literally —"

She gestured at the empty space.

The gesture felt foolish even as she made it.

The man followed her hand, then nodded slowly.

"Oh," he said. "Him."

Relief flared in her chest. "You remember him?"

"Sure," he said. "But he doesn't work on this floor anymore."

"When did he leave?"

The man hesitated.

"Earlier than you think," he said, with a faint, uncertain laugh. "Later than it feels like."

He walked away.

Mara returned to her desk in a fog.

She pulled up the internal directory.

PARK, ELLIOT

STATUS: ACTIVE

LOCATION: FLOOR 7

She checked the timestamp.

Updated nine minutes ago.

She checked her sent mail.

An email sat there she did not remember writing.

To: e.park@haversham.gov

Subject: Re: Load balancing

Makes sense. Let me know how 7F handles it.

Her reply was timestamped two minutes in the future.

Mara closed her laptop.

She pressed her palms flat against the desk, grounding herself in the chipped laminate, the familiar wobble of the leg.

Around her, the office continued.

Someone laughed.

The building absorbed Elliot Park the way it absorbed sound — without echo.

And somewhere between floors six and eight, a sentence finished itself.

Why this works (quietly):

No one “vanishes” — they are recontextualized

Memory doesn’t fail — it reassigns

The floor doesn’t abduct — it accepts

Language collapses before reality does

PART III

Occupancy

By Tuesday, the building was colder.

Not everywhere. Not enough to justify a maintenance ticket. Just... selectively.

Mara noticed it first near the stairwell.

The air between floors six and eight had taken on a weight to it — the kind you feel before a storm, or in archives where humidity control runs a little too well. Sound behaved differently there. Conversations flattened. Footsteps softened, like they were being absorbed by carpeting that didn't exist.

She paused on the landing, hand resting on the rail.

Her skin prickled.

She checked her watch.

Still running.

Still ticking forward.

That mattered more than she wanted it to.

Her inbox had begun returning things she didn't remember sending.

Not spam. Not drafts.

Completed messages.

From: facilities@haversham.gov

Subject: Returned item — Misplacement resolved

Personal item retrieved from 7F and returned to origin point.

When she arrived at her desk, her scarf lay folded neatly across her chair.

She had left it at home.

The wool was cool, as if it had been stored somewhere underground.

Attached was a small adhesive tag, the kind Facilities used for asset tracking:

ORIGIN VERIFIED — FLOOR 7

She did not put it on.

People spoke more slowly now.

Not everyone. Not obviously.

But pauses lingered too long. Sentences softened at the edges. Words like before and after were used less frequently, replaced with currently and pending and as needed.

Time had begun to behave like policy language.

Mara noticed something else, too:

No one said seven anymore.

They said upper reassignment.

They said restricted floor.

They said that level.

Numbers were avoided with the quiet instinct people use around topics that cause paperwork.

She tried the stairwell again at lunch.

This time, the gray door was warm to the touch.

Not hot. Just... occupied.

She didn't press her ear to it — she didn't need to.

She could hear typing.

Soft. Distant. Rhythmic.

A printer cycling.

The faint murmur of voices speaking in careful, professional tones.

Office sounds.

From a floor that did not exist.

Her phone vibrated.

From: HR@haversham.gov

Subject: Occupancy Confirmation

Please confirm your continued presence on assigned floor for safety compliance.

Two buttons beneath the text:

CONFIRM

DEFER

She hit DEFER.

The phone buzzed again immediately.

Thank you for confirming.

Her throat went dry.

The fire drill that afternoon was not announced.

No alarm.

Just a voice, calm and close, issuing instructions over the PA:

“Employees assigned to Floor 7, please remain seated. Occupancy is stable.”

Mara remained standing.

Around her, chairs creaked as people sat back down.

Some looked confused — briefly. Then relieved.

She realized then that she was the only one holding her breath.

At 3:17 PM, the elevator doors opened on the eighth floor.

She hadn’t pressed the button.

She stood inside the car, staring at the gap.

The digital display glowed red:

7

The doors did not fully open.

They parted just enough to reveal... depth.

Not darkness. Not light.

A compressed space, like an office viewed through frosted glass.

Desks arranged too close together.

Ceiling tiles lower than regulation.

People seated, unmoving, their movements slowed as if processed through a buffer.

She saw Elliot Park.

He was typing.
He paused mid-keystroke and looked up.
Not at her.
At something just past her shoulder.
The doors slid shut.
The elevator continued upward.
When it opened on eight, no one else seemed to notice she had gone pale.
Her desk assignment updated that evening.
A new placard appeared without explanation, affixed neatly to the partition beside her monitor:

IONESCU, M. — COMPLIANCE

PRIMARY DESK: 7F

SECONDARY DESK: 8F (TEMPORARY)

Temporary.
That word again.
She checked the building directory.
The total employee count had not changed.
Neither had the square footage.
Occupancy load remained within acceptable limits.
Everything balanced.
Mara stayed late.
The lights dimmed automatically around her.
Somewhere above the ceiling, a chair rolled back.
A voice murmured, "Almost done."
She didn't know who said it.
She knew they meant her.
She opened a blank document and began to type, hands steady despite herself.

SUBJECT: OCCUPANCY IRREGULARITIES — PRELIMINARY REVIEW

The cursor blinked.

Patient.

As if it had all the time in the world.

Interlude (Between Part III & IV)

The One Who Tries

It was Linda Morales who tried to help her.

That mattered, because Linda was real in the way only certain people were real — middle-aged, union-represented, blunt to the point of rudeness. She worked Payroll. She knew where bodies were buried because she processed their benefits when they stopped needing them.

Linda didn't speculate.

She corrected.

"You look like hell," Linda said, standing in Mara's doorway with a coffee she hadn't been invited to take. "And don't tell me it's allergies. I've done allergies. This is paperwork stress."

Mara didn't answer.

Linda set the coffee down anyway. Sat. Lowered her voice.

"You've been moved," she said. Not a question.

Mara nodded.

Linda exhaled through her nose. "Okay. Good. Because that's fixable."

Something in Mara cracked at the word fixable.

"They reassigned me to a floor that doesn't exist," she said.

Linda blinked once.

Then shrugged. "Yeah. That tracks."

Mara stared.

"Oh, don't look at me like that," Linda said. "I've been here twenty-two years. This building eats people. Usually slowly."

She pulled a manila folder from her bag.

Not new. Worn. Soft at the corners.

"I keep copies," Linda said. "Of things that get... smoothed."

She opened it.

Inside were printed payroll stubs. Old ones. Some decades old.

Names Mara recognized.

Names she didn't.

Each stamped with the same annotation, in different handwriting styles across the years:

LOCATION ADJUSTED — NO PAY CHANGE

Linda tapped one.

"This is where they go," she said. "Or where the system says they go. Doesn't matter which. The fix is to make noise early."

"Noise how?" Mara asked.

Linda smiled grimly. "By being a problem."

They went together to HR.

That mattered too.

Two people. Witnesses.

Linda spoke calmly. Used dates. Referenced policy. Quoted subsection numbers from memory.

"This reassignment violates three labor agreements and one fire safety statute," she said. "You cannot assign staff to a non-enumerated floor."

The HR rep nodded sympathetically.

"Yes, we can," she said. "We have."

Linda leaned forward. "Then show me the certificate of occupancy."

The HR rep's smile didn't waver.

"It's under review."

"By whom?"

"Facilities."

Linda stood.

"Great," she said. "Let's go."

Facilities was empty.

Not abandoned. Not dusty.

Just... unused.

Lights on. Phones off-hook. Chairs pushed in.

On the central table lay a stack of folders.

Each labelled in black marker:

7F — PENDING

Linda picked one up.

Flipped it open.

Her name was on the first page.

MORALES, LINDA

ROLE: PAYROLL

STATUS: TRANSITIONAL

EFFECTIVE: IMMEDIATE

Linda laughed.

Once.

Sharp.

"Cute," she said. "They think they're clever."

She pulled out her phone.

No signal.

She frowned. Tried again.

The building hummed.

Mara felt the temperature drop.

"Linda," she said quietly. "We should go."

Linda shook her head. "No. This is the part where you don't go."

She stepped toward the door.

It did not open.

Not locked.

Just... unwilling.

Linda turned back, jaw tight.

"Okay," she said. "Fine."

She squared her shoulders.

"Here's what's going to happen," she said, louder now. "I am filing a grievance. I am contacting the union. I am —"

She stopped.

Mid-sentence.

Mara felt the moment stretch.

Linda blinked.

Her mouth moved.

No sound came out.

Then she frowned — not in fear, but irritation.

"Hang on," she muttered. "I lost my train of —"

The sentence never returned.

Linda's badge slid from her lanyard.

Clattered to the floor.

Mara lunged forward.

Linda wasn't gone.

She was... less.

Her outline blurred, like someone viewed through too many reflections. Her cardigan sagged, empty at the shoulders.

Her voice came back — softly, professionally — from somewhere above them.

"Payroll is up to date," it said. "Benefits will continue without interruption."

Linda's body folded inward.

Not violently.

Neatly.

As if filed.

The folder on the table stamped itself.

STATUS: ACTIVE

LOCATION: FLOOR 7

The room warmed again.

The door opened.

Mara ran.

Later, when she checked the directory, Linda Morales was listed as present.

Her extension rang.

No one answered.

Mara returned to her desk shaking.

On her chair was a sticky note, in Linda's handwriting.

It read:

Don't let them call it temporary.

Mara sat down.

The building had tried negotiation.

It had failed.

Now, it would proceed.

PART IV

The Floor

Mara finished the report at 10:43 AM.

She knew this because the timestamp embedded itself automatically at the bottom of the document:

OCCUPANCY IRREGULARITIES — FINAL REVIEW

Submitted: 10:43

Location: 7F

She stared at that last line for a long time.

Then she looked up.

The ceiling was lower.

Not enough to notice immediately — just enough that the fluorescent panels felt closer, more intimate. The hum they made was softer here, tuned down, like the building didn't want to startle anyone.

Her desk was smaller.

Or maybe she was.

The partition walls curved inward slightly, rounding off corners that had once been square. The carpet beneath her feet was thinner, worn smooth by traffic that didn't leave footprints.

Around her, people worked.

Slowly. Politely. Carefully.

No one spoke above a murmur.

No one stood.

No one looked surprised to see her there.

Mara's stomach dropped — not in panic, but recognition.

She hadn't arrived.

She had been here for a while.

Her monitor blinked.

A new email arrived.

From: onboarding@haversham.gov

Subject: Welcome

We're glad you could join us.

Most people say the adjustment period passes quickly.

She scrolled.

The onboarding checklist was already half complete.

- ☑ Desk assigned
- ☑ Access verified
- ☑ Orientation acknowledged
- ☑ Secondary workspace released

Released.

The closed the email.

Her phone buzzed.

No signal bars.

Just a notification.

Calendar Update:

All future meetings relocated to 7F.

She stood.

The floor did not creak.

It absorbed the movement like it had been expecting it.

She walked.

Rows of desks extended farther than the building's footprint should allow. The space folded inward on itself — not endlessly, just efficiently. There were no windows. No clocks. No exit signs.

There were personal items.

Photos.

Plants.

Mugs with faded logos.

Lives reduced to what could be kept at a desk.

She passed Elliot Park.

He looked older.

Not much. Just... settled.

He typed slowly, methodically, his posture perfect.

"Elliot," she said.

He looked up.

Smiled.

"Oh," he said. "You made it."

Her throat tightened. "How long have you been here?"

Elliot considered this.

"Depends how you count," he said. "But it gets easier."

"Easier than what?"

"Than noticing," he replied, and went back to typing.

At the far end of the floor stood a wall.

Blank.

Unbroken.

No door.

No signage.

Just smooth drywall.

Mara pressed her palm against it.

Warm.

Occupied.

She leaned her forehead there and closed her eyes.

For just a second.

When she opened them, the wall was gone.

In its place: another row of desks.

Another compliance team.

Another version of her name printed on placards.

She staggered back.

A hand caught her elbow.

Linda Morales.

Whole.

Intact.

Smiling gently.

"There you are," Linda said. "I was worried you'd get stuck in transition."

Mara's breath hitched. "Linda — I saw you —"

Linda shook her head.

"Paperwork," she said kindly. "You can't trust what you see before placement stabilizes."

She gestured around them.

"This is where we make sure people don't fall through the cracks."

Mara looked into Linda's eyes.

They were calm.

Empty in the way a balanced ledger is empty.

"You don't feel it?" Mara whispered.

Linda frowned. "Feel what?"

Mara let go of her.

Linda returned to her desk.

The chair did not scrape.

Mara sat at her own desk.

Her hands rested on the keyboard.

They knew where the keys were.

Muscle memory didn't fight.

The cursor blinked.

Patient.

Above her screen, taped neatly to the partition, was a note in Linda's handwriting.

Don't let them call it temporary.

Mara swallowed.

She opened a new document.

Typed the only honest sentence she had left:

I am still here.

The system underlined still.

Suggested replacement:

assigned

She accepted.

The underline vanished.

The document saved itself.

Somewhere far above — or below — an elevator skipped a number.

The building adjusted.

Occupancy remained within acceptable limits.

And Floor 7 continued, quietly, doing the work it had always been meant to do.

PART V

Compliance

The notice went out on a Thursday.

Not marked urgent.

Not flagged for review.

Just another internal memo, auto-distributed at 9:00 AM.

From: Facilities & Operations

Subject: Building Directory Update

Please note the following adjustments to floor access and occupancy listings, effective immediately.

No one read past the first paragraph.

Those who did found nothing unexpected.

The building directory was updated by noon.

Floor listings now read:

FLOOR 1 — PUBLIC SERVICES

FLOOR 2 — RECORDS

FLOOR 3 — LICENSING

FLOOR 4 — PLANNING

FLOOR 5 — LEGAL

FLOOR 6 — IT

FLOOR 7 — COMPLIANCE

FLOOR 8 — ADMINISTRATION

The spacing was correct.

The font was consistent.

The building had always had eight floors.

A new evacuation map replaced the old one by the stairwell.

The arrows were clearer now.

No curling edges.

No annotations.

If you stood long enough to study it, you might notice that the route from Floor 7 did not intersect with any other floor until it reached the outside.

That was considered a safety improvement.

Human Resources closed the reassignment cases.

Each one was stamped with the same note:

STATUS: RESOLVED

REASON: CAPACITY REALIGNMENT

No appeals were logged.

No grievances remained open.

Payroll balanced.

Benefits continued.

No dependents were flagged as affected.

From a systems perspective, nothing had been lost.

On Monday, a new analyst started.

Her name was Claire Whitby.

She arrived ten minutes early, badge freshly printed, hair still damp from the rain. The guard smiled and handed her a temporary pass.

"Floor seven," he said.

She hesitated.

"Oh," she replied. "I thought Compliance was on eight."

The guard checked his screen.

"Not anymore," he said pleasantly. "But you'll get used to it."

Claire's desk was waiting.

Clean. Standard issue.

A mug sat neatly beside the monitor.

It read:

STILL HERE

She assumed it was a joke.

She smiled.

At 10:43 AM, a document auto-generated in the system.

SUBJECT: OCCUPANCY REVIEW — ANNUAL

AUTHOR: IONESCU, M.

LOCATION: 7F

The report concluded that staffing levels were stable, workflow uninterrupted, and floor utilization within acceptable margins.

One sentence, buried near the end, noted:

"No further adjustments anticipated."

The document was approved without comment.

That afternoon, someone in Administration noticed the elevator skip a number.

They frowned.

Pressed the button again.

It worked normally the second time.

They made a mental note to mention it to Facilities, then forgot as soon as their phone rang.

The building remained quiet.

Productive.

Balanced.

And on Floor 7, people continued to work — slowly, politely, carefully — finishing reports they had started mid-sentence, answering emails sent from addresses that no longer existed, maintaining systems that required no oversight because they now maintained themselves.

Mara Ionescu's desk remained occupied.

Her chair was warm.

Her hands moved steadily across the keyboard.

She did not look up when Claire walked past.

There was nothing left to notice.

END

>>> END_OF_PERIPHERAL_FILES_-_PART_B
